

The Black Cat

Edgar Allan Poe · 1843

First published: Saturday Evening Post, Aug 1843

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Black_Cat (revision 14833565), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Black Cat suggest about guilt and perversity?
- What does The Black Cat suggest about alcohol and violence?
- What does The Black Cat suggest about confession?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Black Cat	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*guilt and perversity* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Black Cat

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Edgar Allan Poe's life or times connects to guilt and perversity in “The Black Cat”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (guilt and perversity, alcohol and violence, confession).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

The temperance movement was strong in 1840s America, and stories of men ruined by drink were a popular genre; Poe, who struggled with alcohol himself, gives the genre a psychological twist. The cat's name, Pluto, is that of the Roman god of the underworld, and black cats carried old folk associations with witchcraft.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the United States Saturday Post (Philadelphia) on 19 August 1843.

Then: Popular with readers of sensational fiction.

Now: Read alongside "The Tell-Tale Heart" as a study of guilt, perversity and the unreliable narrator.

Overview (spoiler-free)

On the night before his execution, a narrator tells how he went from a gentle animal lover to a violent drunk, and how his cruelty toward his cat Pluto led to worse crimes.

Main themes

- perversity: the urge to do wrong "for the wrong's sake."
- guilt and self-betrayal: as in "Tell-Tale," he exposes himself.
- alcohol and violence: domestic abuse is presented without excuse.

Why it matters

Students examine how a narrator excuses himself, and how a story can show the progression of abuse.

Spoilers · teacher only

He hangs Pluto, a second cat with a gallows-shaped mark appears, and when he tries to kill it he murders his wife instead and walls her up in the cellar; the cat, walled in with her, screams and betrays him to the police.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Black Cat: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?
Prompt: Before we open The Black Cat: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
unreliable narrator; perversity; foreshadowing; superstition; confession.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. The temperance movement was strong in 1840s America, and stories of men ruined by drink were a popular genre; Poe, who struggled with alcohol himself, gives the genre a psychological twist. The cat's name, Pluto, is that of the Roman god of the underworld, and black cats carried old folk associations with witchcraft. Publication and reception. First published in the United States Saturday Post (Philadelphia) on 19 August 1843. Then: Popular with readers of sensational fiction. Now: Read alongside "The Tell-Tale Heart" as a study of guilt, perversity and the unreliable narrator.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "For the most wild, yet most homely narrative which I am about to pen, I neither expect nor solicit belief" slowly and put it in my own words: Before he tells his story, the narrator says it is both wild and homely, and he does not expect belief. Next, craft. I notice the paradox "most wild, yet most homely," strange and ordinary at once. The strongest word is "homely": it means plain, everyday, and it warns us that the horror will happen inside an ordinary house. Then, effect. Why does the narrator say he neither expects nor asks us to believe him? My answer: Poe opens with an unreliable narrator who protests too much; refusing to ask for belief makes us lean in and doubt him at the same time.

> *For the most wild, yet most homely narrative which I am about to pen, I neither expect nor solicit belief (The Black Cat, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "For the most wild, yet most homely narrative which I am about to pen, I neither expect nor solicit belief" slowly and put it in my own words: Before he tells his story, the narrator says it is both wild and homely, and he does not expect belief. Next, craft. I notice the paradox "most wild, yet most homely," strange and ordinary at once. The strongest word is "homely": it means plain, everyday, and it warns us that the horror will happen inside an ordinary house. Then, effect. Why does the narrator say he neither expects nor asks us to believe him? My answer: Poe opens with an unreliable narrator who protests too much; refusing to ask for belief makes us lean in and doubt him at the same time.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): On the night before his execution, a narrator tells how he went from a gentle animal lover to a violent drunk, and how his cruelty toward his cat Pluto led to worse crimes. Themes to track: perversity: the urge to do wrong "for the wrong's sake." guilt and self-betrayal: as in "Tell-Tale," he exposes himself. alcohol and violence: domestic abuse is presented without excuse.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: guilt and confession. Prediction: a narrator who insists he is not mad and is telling a "homely" story will reveal more than he means to. Question: why does he want to tell this story the night before he dies?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Black Cat: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: guilt and confession. Prediction: a narrator who insists he is not mad and is telling a "homely" story will reveal more than he means to. Question: why does he want to tell this story the night before he dies?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Black Cat still matter? Students examine how a narrator excuses himself, and how a story can show the progression of abuse.
Anchor question: Why might The Black Cat still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students examine how a narrator excuses himself, and how a story can show the progression of abuse.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
In an 1842 review of Hawthorne's Twice-Told Tales, Poe argued that a short tale should build one "single effect," and he published "The Black Cat" in the Saturday Evening Post in 1843. What effect do you expect Poe to aim for, and why would magazine readers want it? Answer: Accept answers such as: a single feeling like horror or dread built from the first sentence; short, gripping tales sold magazines like the Post and could be read in one sitting.
Exit ticket: In an 1842 review of Hawthorne's Twice-Told Tales, Poe argued that a short tale should build one "single effect," and he published "The Black Cat" in the Saturday Evening Post in 1843. What effect do you expect Poe to aim for, and why would magazine readers want it?
Answer: Accept answers such as: a single feeling like horror or dread built from the first sentence; short, gripping tales sold magazines like the Post and could be read in one sitting.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Black Cat.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Black Cat" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/blctcata.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: animal cruelty and the murder of a wife. Preview with students and offer an alternative if needed.

Lesson 2: The Black Cat

Focus: self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

Objective: Students will analyze how point of view develops in “The Black Cat” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse): Sensitive content: Animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape of a gallows. Trying to kill it, he murders his wife with an axe and walls her body up in the cellar. When police search, he raps on the wall, and the cat's howl reveals the corpse; he had walled the cat in with her.

Background: Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence.

Significance: Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to perversity because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse.
Prompt: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to perversity because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: deliberated — thought carefully about; endeared — made loved or liked; allayed — lessen the intensity of or calm; hangman — an executioner who hangs the condemned person; nurtured — help develop, help grow. “deliberated”: From Latin deliberare "to weigh well," from de- (intensive) + librare "to balance," from libra "scales." (Not from liber "free.") “nurtured”: Origin of “nurture”: Old French norriture; earlier Late Latin nutritura (“nourishment”).
Words: deliberated: thought carefully about · endeared: made loved or liked · allayed: lessen the intensity of or calm · hangman: an executioner who hangs the condemned person · nurtured: help develop, help grow

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence. Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology. Point of view: A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself. Foreshadowing: The wife's mention of witches who take the form of cats, and the gallows-shaped white patch, foreshadow his end. Irony: His boastful rapping on the wall that hides the corpse summons the cat's cry. Watch for the cat: conscience and retribution; Pluto, god of the dead.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” slowly and put it in my own words: He says his final downfall came from a spirit of perverseness, an urge to do wrong just because it is wrong. Next, craft. I notice he capitalizes Perverseness and calls it a "spirit," as if it were a force outside him. The strongest word is “irrevocable”: it means beyond undoing, so he admits the damage was permanent. Then, effect. Why does the narrator blame "the spirit of Perverseness" for what he did? My answer: Blaming a named spirit lets him avoid admitting that he chose to do it; Poe shows a narrator explaining his cruelty away, and we should trust him less because of it.

> *And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness (The Black Cat, paragraph 9)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” slowly and put it in my own words: He says his final downfall came from a spirit of perverseness, an urge to do wrong just because it is wrong. Next, craft. I notice he capitalizes Perverseness and calls it a "spirit," as if it were a force outside him. The strongest word is “irrevocable”: it means beyond undoing, so he admits the damage was permanent. Then, effect. Why does the narrator blame "the spirit of Perverseness" for what he did? My answer: Blaming a named spirit lets him avoid admitting that he chose to do it; Poe shows a narrator explaining his cruelty away, and we should trust him less because of it.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Calling the cat "the monster" shifts the guilt from himself to the animal; the reader sees he is the monster. Ask: How does this line connect to perversity? Expected: He names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. (The final line.)

> *I had walled the monster up within the tomb (The Black Cat, paragraph 32)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Calling the cat "the monster" shifts the guilt from himself to the animal; the reader sees he is the monster.
Ask: How does this line connect to perversity?
Expected answer: He names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. (The final line.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Black Cat develops the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. When the text says “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9), it shows this directly. He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Black Cat develops the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. When the text says “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9), it shows this directly. He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong? Compare with "The Tell-Tale Heart": which narrator is more self-aware?
Anchor question: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?
Facilitation: Compare with "The Tell-Tale Heart": which narrator is more self-aware?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. ("And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness", The Black Cat, paragraph 9). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. ("And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness", The Black Cat, paragraph 9). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Key takeaway: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself.
- **Foreshadowing:** The wife's mention of witches who take the form of cats, and the gallows-shaped white patch, foreshadow his end.
- **Irony:** His boastful rapping on the wall that hides the corpse summons the cat's cry.

Themes and how they develop

- **perversity:** he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse.

Symbols and motifs

- **the cat:** conscience and retribution; Pluto, god of the dead.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness" (The Black Cat, paragraph 9) His theory of motive.
- "I had walled the monster up within the tomb" (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) The final line.
- "the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder" (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) He blames the cat for his own crime.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices.
Evidence: "And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness" (The Black Cat, paragraph 9)
Reasoning: He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
deliberated (verb)	thought carefully about	*Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.*	"deliberated": From Latin deliberare "to weigh well," from de- (intensive) + librare "to balance," from libra "scales." (Not from liber "free.") (Online Etymology Dictionary (hand-checked note), https://www.etymonline.com/word/deliberate)
endeared (verb)	made loved or liked	*This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my simplest and purest pleasures.*	
allayed (verb)	lessen the intensity of or calm	*"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.*	
hangman (noun)	an executioner who hangs the condemned person	*Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.*	
nurtured (verb)	help develop, help grow	*My original soul seemed, at once, to take its flight from my body; and a more than fiendish malevolence, gin-nurtured, thrilled every fibre of my frame.*	"nurtured": Origin of "nurture": Old French norriture; earlier Late Latin nutritura ("nourishment"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/nurture#Etymology)
consigned (verb)	commit forever; commit irrevocably	*Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced*	

		me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.	
procuring (verb)	get by special effort	*Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of procuring those of the most agreeable kind.*	
abusing (verb)	treat badly	*I avoided the creature; a certain sense of shame, and the remembrance of my former deed of cruelty, preventing me from physically abusing it.*	
informing (verb)	impart knowledge of some fact, state or affairs, or event to	*Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.*	"informing": Origin of "inform": Old French enformer; earlier Latin īnfōrmō ("to shape"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inform#Etymology)
irritable (adjective)	easily irritated or annoyed	*I grew, day by day, more moody, more irritable, more regardless of the feelings of others.*	"irritable": Origin: French irritable; earlier Latin irritabilis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/irritable#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with guilt and perversity?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the name of the narrator's first cat? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Pluto
2. What does the narrator blame for his change in temper? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'
3. What appears on the wall after the fire? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck

4. What shape does the white patch on the second cat take? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A gallows
5. What exposes the murder? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The cat's cry from behind the wall
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Black Cat" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape of a gallows. Trying to kill it, he murders his wife with an axe and walls her body up in the cellar…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Black Cat"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Black Cat" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house." What does "deliberated" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: deliberated: thought carefully about.
10. Reread: "This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my…" What does "endeared" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: endeared: made loved or liked.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Black Cat" suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: "And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness" (The Black Cat, paragraph 9): His theory of motive. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own.", why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.

5. What causes the main turn in “The Black Cat”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Black Cat” set up that the rest of The Black Cat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): The final line. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): He blames the cat for his own crime. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with guilt and perversity? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9): His theory of motive. On irony: His boastful rapping on the wall that hides the corpse summons the cat's cry. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): The final line. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): He blames the cat for his own crime. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9): His theory of motive. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Black Cat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): The final line. On point of view: A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Black Cat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): He blames the cat for his own crime. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to alcohol and violence: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9): His theory of motive. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): The final line. On point of view: A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Black Cat” treats self-destruction and the urge to do wrong with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Black Cat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): He blames the cat for his own crime. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve guilt and perversity? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9): His theory of motive. On foreshadowing: The wife's mention of witches who take the form of cats, and the gallows-shaped white patch, foreshadow his end. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): The final line. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Useful evidence: “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32): He blames the cat for his own crime. Theme link: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the name of the narrator's first cat?

   A. Lucifer

   B. Shadow

   C. Pluto

   D. Midnight

   Key: C (Pluto)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 32: “I had walled the _____ up within the tomb”

   Key: monster

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the narrator blame for his change in temper?

   A. His wife

   B. Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'

   C. His job

   D. The cat

   Key: B (Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance')

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What shape does the white patch on the second cat take?

   A. A heart

   B. A key

   C. A gallows

   D. A star

   Key: C (A gallows)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 9: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of _____”

   Key: Perverseness

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What appears on the wall after the fire?

   A. A door

   B. The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck

   C. His initials

   D. A painted cross

   Key: B (The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My original soul seemed, at once, to take its flight from my body; and a more than fiendish malevolence, gin-_____, thrilled every fibre of my

frame." Word bank: endeared, nurtured, deliberated, allayed

Key: nurtured

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had _____ me to the hangman." Word bank: deliberated, consigned, allayed, endeared

   Key: consigned

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I avoided the creature; a certain sense of shame, and the remembrance of my former deed of cruelty, preventing me from physically _____ it." Word bank: allayed, deliberated, abusing, endeared

   Key: abusing

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What exposes the murder?

    A. A letter

    B. A neighbor's testimony

    C. The cat's cry from behind the wall

    D. Blood on the floor

    Key: C (The cat's cry from behind the wall)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Black Cat"?

    A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

    B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    C. What fifteen years of solitude teach

    D. The hunter becoming the hunted

    Key: B (Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "I had walled the monster up within the tomb" (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The final line.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness" (The Black Cat, paragraph 9) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His theory of motive.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness" (The Black Cat, paragraph 9).

    Sample answer: He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Black Cat"? The wife's mention of witches who take the form of cats, and the gallows-shaped white patch, foreshadow his end.

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Irony

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Setting

Key: A (Foreshadowing)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His theory of motive.
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 32: “the _____ beast whose craft had seduced me into murder”
    Key: hideous
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of _____ those of the most agreeable kind.” Word bank: deliberated, allayed, procuring, endeared
    Key: procuring
19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: He blames the cat for his own crime.
20. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Black Cat”? A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself.
    A. Metaphor
    B. Point of view
    C. Plot
    D. Conflict

    Key: B (Point of view)
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how perversity develops from an earlier story to “The Black Cat”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The final line.
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.”, what does “hangman” most nearly mean?
    A. made loved or liked
    B. thought carefully about
    C. lessen the intensity of or calm
    D. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    Key: D (an executioner who hangs the condemned person)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.”, what does “deliberated” most nearly mean?

    A. made loved or liked

    B. thought carefully about

    C. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    D. lessen the intensity of or calm

    Key: B (thought carefully about)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.”, what does “allayed” most nearly mean?

    A. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    B. made loved or liked

    C. thought carefully about

    D. lessen the intensity of or calm

    Key: D (lessen the intensity of or calm)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my…”, what does “endeared” most nearly mean?

    A. thought carefully about

    B. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    C. lessen the intensity of or calm

    D. made loved or liked

    Key: D (made loved or liked)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 5, 3, 1, 4, 17, 8, 10, 18, 13, 11, 12, 14, 19, 20, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 2, 10, 1, 4, 8, 9, 6, 12, 11, 13, 15, 20, 14, 21, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 7, 4, 10, 9, 6, 2, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 20, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 8, 17, 5, 2, 6, 13, 11, 12, 15, 20, 19, 14, 22, 21, 23	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 6, 2, 24, 3, 11, 12, 13, 19, 20, 15, 14, 21, 16, 22, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 8, 3, 24, 25, 12, 13, 11, 15, 14, 19, 20, 23, 16, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 6, 5, 4, 26, 11, 13, 12, 15, 20, 14, 19, 21, 22, 16, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	24, 4, 8, 27, 17, 13, 12, 11, 20, 19, 14, 15, 22, 23, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 2, 1, 6, 27, 13, 11, 12, 19, 20, 14, 15, 23, 16, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	26, 5, 4, 8, 3, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 20, 19, 23, 22, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Black Cat,” how does Poe show self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In The Black Cat, how does Poe develop the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Black Cat develops the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Black Cat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Black Cat suggests about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses point of view in The Black Cat to complicate the reader's understanding of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Black Cat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Black Cat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Black Cat and its treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Black Cat as evidence for a larger claim about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong in The Black Cat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Black Cat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Black Cat.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “allayed” most nearly mean?

   A. lessen the intensity of or calm

   B. easily irritated or annoyed

   C. treat badly

   D. impart knowledge of some fact, state or affairs, or event to

2. *I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own. Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of procuring those of the most agreeable kind. We had birds, gold-fish, a fine dog, rabbits, a small monkey, and a cat.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Black Cat”?

   A. Science that poisons love

   B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

   C. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

   D. The loss of faith in human goodness

SAT key: 1. A (lessen the intensity of or calm); 2. B (Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong)

Unit test

The Black Cat: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What shape does the white patch on the second cat take?
   A. A heart
   B. A key
   C. A gallows
   D. A star

   Key: C (A gallows)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My original soul seemed, at once, to take its flight from my body; and a more than fiendish malevolence, gin-_____, thrilled every fibre of my frame.” Word bank: endeared, nurtured, deliberated, allayed

   Key: nurtured
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What exposes the murder?
   A. A letter
   B. A neighbor's testimony
   C. The cat's cry from behind the wall
   D. Blood on the floor

   Key: C (The cat's cry from behind the wall)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of _____ those of the most agreeable kind.” Word bank: deliberated, allayed, procuring, endeared

   Key: procuring
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 32: “I had walled the _____ up within the tomb”

   Key: monster
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 32: “the _____ beast whose craft had seduced me into murder”

   Key: hideous

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What appears on the wall after the fire?

   A. A door

   B. The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck

   C. His initials

   D. A painted cross

   Key: B (The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Black Cat, paragraph 9: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of _____”

   Key: Perverseness

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the name of the narrator's first cat?

   A. Lucifer

   B. Shadow

   C. Pluto

   D. Midnight

   Key: C (Pluto)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had _____ me to the hangman.” Word bank: deliberated, consigned, allayed, endeared

    Key: consigned

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the narrator blame for his change in temper?

    A. His wife

    B. Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'

    C. His job

    D. The cat

    Key: B (Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance')

12. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I avoided the creature; a certain sense of shame, and the remembrance of my former deed of cruelty, preventing me from physically _____ it.” Word bank: allayed, deliberated, abusing, endeared

    Key: abusing

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The final line.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His theory of motive.

15. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Black Cat”?

    A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

    B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    C. What fifteen years of solitude teach

    D. The hunter becoming the hunted

Key: B (Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong)

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Black Cat”? A condemned man narrates; he calls the events "homely," yet they are monstrous, and he blames forces outside himself.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Point of view

    C. Plot

    D. Conflict

    Key: B (Point of view)

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Black Cat”? The wife's mention of witches who take the form of cats, and the gallows-shaped white patch, foreshadow his end.

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Irony

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Setting

    Key: A (Foreshadowing)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I had walled the monster up within the tomb” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The final line.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9).
    Sample answer: He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder” (The Black Cat, paragraph 32). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: He blames the cat for his own crime.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The narrator blames outside forces, but the story shows his crimes come from his own choices.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He calls perverseness a force that came "as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow," as though it acted on him, yet he chooses every act, and his own boast brings the police to the wall where "I had walled the monster up within the tomb."

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “And then came, as if to my final and irrevocable overthrow, the spirit of Perverseness” (The Black Cat, paragraph 9) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His theory of motive.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how perversity develops from an earlier story to “The Black Cat”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: he names "the spirit of PERVERSENESS" as a basic human impulse.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.”, what does “hangman” most nearly mean?

    A. made loved or liked

    B. thought carefully about

    C. lessen the intensity of or calm

    D. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    Key: D (an executioner who hangs the condemned person)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.”, what does “deliberated” most nearly mean?

    A. made loved or liked

    B. thought carefully about

    C. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    D. lessen the intensity of or calm

    Key: B (thought carefully about)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.”, what does “allayed” most nearly mean?

    A. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    B. made loved or liked

    C. thought carefully about

    D. lessen the intensity of or calm

    Key: D (lessen the intensity of or calm)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my…”, what does “endeared” most nearly mean?

    A. thought carefully about

    B. an executioner who hangs the condemned person

    C. lessen the intensity of or calm

    D. made loved or liked

    Key: D (made loved or liked)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	3, 1, 10, 12, 5, 8, 4, 2, 6, 9, 7, 13, 15, 14, 17, 16, 19, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 9, 1, 2, 7, 3, 6, 4, 10, 11, 14, 15, 13, 17, 20, 16, 21, 22	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	3, 10, 8, 4, 12, 5, 1, 9, 6, 15, 13, 14, 17, 20, 16, 19, 21, 22	

		recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 11, 10, 12, 6, 3, 8, 2, 14, 15, 13, 16, 19, 20, 17, 18, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	2, 10, 6, 1, 4, 7, 9, 13, 15, 14, 19, 20, 17, 16, 22, 21, 18, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 6, 4, 12, 24, 11, 2, 13, 15, 14, 17, 16, 20, 19, 23, 22, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	12, 1, 8, 9, 4, 6, 10, 15, 13, 14, 16, 19, 17, 20, 21, 23, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	10, 1, 9, 2, 8, 7, 25, 14, 13, 15, 20, 16, 17, 19, 21, 18, 22, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	5, 11, 12, 25, 26, 9, 1, 15, 14, 13, 17, 19, 20, 16, 18, 21, 23, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	5, 27, 1, 10, 2, 8, 12, 13, 14, 15, 20, 17, 19, 16, 22, 21, 18, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Black Cat: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and perversity across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Black Cat and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to alcohol and violence.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Black Cat. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Black Cat finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of confession. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Guilt and perversity

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about guilt and perversity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and perversity across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of guilt and perversity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of guilt and perversity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of guilt and perversity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about guilt and perversity in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Alcohol and violence

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about alcohol and violence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops alcohol and violence across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of alcohol and violence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of alcohol and violence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of alcohol and violence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about alcohol and violence in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Confession

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about confession. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops confession in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops confession across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of confession. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of confession in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of confession, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of confession in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on confession in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on confession in The Black Cat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about confession in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on confession in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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